

you. Last week, when I went there, she was asking me about you. I promised to bring you along the next time. But be a good boy and don't insult her again,' he said.

'Don't try your cock-and-bull story on me. Keep it for the fund managers,' I said. But deep in my heart I was hoping what he said was true. Much as I hated to admit it to Lucky, I was smitten by Payal in that single meeting. I kept thinking of the seductive glances she had thrown me, nearly to the point of distraction. In fact, I was looking for an excuse to go back to White House, and was delighted at Lucky's invitation.

To cut a long story short, I went there a few more times. Payal was the hottest item in White House at the time, and she had many suitors vying for her attention. And yet she chose me as the object of her attention, much to the annoyance of aspirants far wealthier and powerful than me. Among them happened to be an uncouth businessman in his mid-forties who ran a chain of Udipi hotels and a diamond trader rumoured to have underworld connections. They showered her with all kinds of expensive gifts, and yet she would have eyes only for me whenever I was there.

The hotelier was so mad at me that on one occasion he threatened me in public.

Once I was at the White House and it happened to be Payal's birthday. After her performance, she sent word that I join her in her room with some of her colleagues for the customary cake-cutting ritual. Of all the patrons present that evening, I was the only one she chose to invite. And it was done in such a manner that everybody around got to know of it.

I thought I was in love with Payal and felt that she too had a soft corner for me. But that delusion was shattered a couple of months later when I learnt from Lucky that she was having a good time with both the hotelier and the diamond trader. The only reason she chose to indulge me in public was to get the other two worked up and lavish more money on her. In market parlance, she was using me as a bait to get them to up their bids.

The experience drained me emotionally and affected my trading too. Even otherwise, 1996 was a terrible year for the stock market. The economy was slowing, companies were struggling after having embarked on ambitious capacity expansions, and the primary market had slipped into a coma.